In early 2022, when Santishree Pandit became the vice-chancellor (VC) of Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU), she inherited a fund deficit of Rs 130 crore, an agitated student body and a campus where many infrastructure and academic projects had been on hold for nearly two years. Since last year, however, her focus has not only been to restore normalcy to the students, faculty and the administration, but also to raise funds and restart the refurbishment of the campus.

To boost revenue, the university is looking at several options—from engaging private players and alumni to setting up regional language centres. In December last year, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin sanctioned Rs 10 crore to set up the Centre for Tamil Studies. There are possibilities of other states following suit too. E-learning is being considered as an option to generate fresh revenue by taking JNU academics to a wider audience. "We have signed MoUs with several foreign universities for collaborations, and about 5-10 per cent of the proceeds from that would go towards funding students' field visits," says Pandit. JNU has also applied for a loan of Rs 500 crore from the Higher Education Financing Agency. It is also awaiting an Institute of Eminence tag from the Union ministry of education, which brings in a grant of Rs 1,000 crore. These fresh funds are needed not just to rebuild old buildings on campus but to set up fresh ones for new courses and centres.

The university is also working to adjust to the new National Education Policy. While JNU is primarily a master's campus, it does offer a BA programme in languages, which will soon become a four-year master's programme. "Several specialised master's programmes will also be introduced. For example, skill development is becoming very important and simply having a degree to your name is not enough. Students need to have various other skill sets for employment and we need to give them such opportunities to learn on campus," says Prof. P.R. Kumaraswamy, director of international collaborations. The university has already signed an agreement with the Centurion University of Technology and Management to collaborate on integrating skills, entrepreneurship and innovation. Such partnerships are being done with institutes from around the

GURUSPEAK

"JNU is the most inclusive university in the country. Thanks to our affordable fee structure, we have students from all walks of life and parts of the country"



SANTISHREE PANDIT
VICE CHANCELLOR, JNU

TOP 10

GENERAL UNIVERSITIES (GOVERNMENT)

RANK 2023	RANK 2022	RANK 2021	RANK 2020	RANK 2019	UNIVERSITY
1	1	1	1	1	JAWAHARLAL NEHRU UNIVERSITY, NEW DELHI
2	2	2	NP	NP	UNIVERSITY OF DELHI, NEW DELHI
3	4	4	3	3	ALIGARH MUSLIM UNIVERSITY, ALIGARH
4	3	3	2	2	UNIVERSITY OF HYDERABAD, HYDERABAD
5	5	6	8	7	JAMIA MILLIA ISLAMIA, NEW DELHI
6	6	5	5	5	UNIVERSITY OF CALCUTTA, KOLKATA
7	7	NP	4	4	OSMANIA UNIVERSITY, HYDERABAD
8	NP	NP	NP	NP	UNIVERSITY OF MADRAS, CHENNAI
9	12	12	NP	NP	GURU GOBIND SINGH INDRAPRASTHA UNIVERSITY, NEW DELHI
10	9	9	10	NP	DR. RAJENDRA PRASAD CENTRAL AGRICULTURAL UNIVERSITY, PUSA, SAMASTIPUR